University of Florida
College of Public Health & Health Professions Syllabus

PHC 6700: Social and Behavioral Research Methods (3 credits)

Spring: 2026

Delivery Format: On-Campus

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PURPOSE AND OUTCOME

Course Overview

This course is designed to provide an overview of research design, methods, and ethics for graduate students in public health, with an emphasis in the social and behavioral sciences. The overarching aims for the course are to provide students with: (1) an overview of the types of research methods available; (2) the opportunity to design, conduct, and evaluate research projects; and (3) an understanding of key ethical, cultural, and political impacts related to the conduct of research. We will use a variety of instructional methods to address these aims, including readings, discussions, projects, online activities, and hands-on research experiences.

Relation to Program Outcomes

The overarching aims for this course are to provide students with: 1) an overview of the types of research methods available; 2) the opportunity to design, conduct, and evaluate research projects; and 3) understanding of key ethical and cultural considerations related to the conduct of research.

Course Objectives and/or Goals

It is expected that, by the end of this course, PHC6700, students will be able to:

1.0 Characterize the purpose and need for social and behavioral research in the health sciences
2.0 Distinguish key ethical issues associated with different methods of research
3.0 Compose research questions and hypotheses
4.0 Compare and contrast the key features of observational, qualitative, correlational, quasi-experimental, and experimental research designs
5.0 Integrate basic quantitative and qualitative methods into the design of research to align with specific research questions
6.0 Develop a research proposal that describes a researchable problem, the purpose of the study, the academic context of the study, sampling strategies, methodology, proposed analyses, and implications of potential findings
7.0 Communicate research designs in written and oral formats
8.0 Critique the research design, process, and analysis of their own work and the research of others

Blended Learning

A Blended Learning class uses a mixture of technology and face-to-face instruction to help you maximize your learning. Knowledge content that, as the instructor, I would have traditionally presented during a live class lecture is instead provided online before the live class takes place. This lets me focus my face-to-face teaching on course activities designed to help you strengthen higher order thinking skills such as critical thinking, problem solving, and collaboration. Competency in these skills is critical for today's health professional.

What is expected of you?

You are expected to actively engage in the course throughout the semester. You must come to class prepared by completing all out-of-class assignments. This preparation gives you the knowledge or practice needed to engage in higher levels of learning during the live class sessions. If you are not prepared for the face-to-face sessions, you may struggle to keep pace with the activities occurring in the live sessions, and it is unlikely that you will reach the higher learning goals of the course. Similarly, you are expected to actively participate in the live class. Your participation fosters a rich course experience for you and your peers that facilitates overall mastery of the course objectives.

DESCRIPTION OF COURSE CONTENT

Topical Outline/Course Schedule

Week	Topic(s)	Readings
1	Introductions, Course Overview, The Need for Social Research in Health	Syllabus, Canvas Module Pages
2	Martin Luther King Holiday (No Class)	
3	Scientific Methods and Ethical Decisions	IRB 803 Training
4	Forming Research Questions and Foundational Paradigms for Scientific Inquiries	Chapter 3 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
5	The Literature Review	Chapter 5 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
6	Quantitative Methods and Designs	Chapters 4 and 6 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
7	Qualitative Methods and Designs	Chapter 10 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
8	Mixed-Methods and Sampling Methods	Chapter 7 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
9	Interviewing: Structured and Qualitative	Chapter 11 of Online Textbook
10	Spring Break (No Class)	
11	Self-Completion Questionnaires	Chapter 8 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
12	Observational Research and Focus Groups	Chapter 12 of Online Textbook
13	Quantitative Data Analysis	Chapter 4 of Online Textbook and Assigned Research Article
14	Qualitative Data Analysis	Focus Group Transcript
15	Research Presentations	Chapter 15 of Online Textbook

Course Materials and Technology

Sheppard, V. (2020). *Research Methods for the Social Sciences: An Introduction.* Creative Commons. Free Online Web Textbook

Additional required readings will be posted within each module on the Canvas Course website

Please bring your laptops to each class period. Laptops and other electronics should only be used when appropriate for taking notes or completing in-class activities. This course will use the Canvas CMS. Class announcements will be sent via the announcements tool in Canvas. Depending on your Canvas notification settings, you may or may not be notified via email; you are responsible for all information in these announcements, whether or not you see them in your email.

ACADEMIC REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

Assignments

Preparation, In-Class Contributions, and In-Class Assessments – 20% of Final Grade

All students will be expected to make informed contributions during in-class activities and team-based problem solving. Since research is most often done in teams, your contributions to your assigned research team will also count toward this score. You will receive feedback on your score in the middle of the course with input for how to improve the score if necessary. This means that you come to class prepared to discuss the readings, contribute to or lead discussions, and display a command of the topics at hand through in-class readiness assessments such as multiple choice quizzes, homework assignments, and in-class handout completion. You are also expected to display professional courtesy to your peers when providing feedback and constructive criticism. A rubric for scoring this activity is provided within Canvas.

Research Proposal (Due 4/13/26) – 60% of Final Grade

You will complete a research proposal over the course of the semester and have the opportunity to submit sections in stages. I will provide you feedback on these sections to improve your final submission. A detailed rubric will be provided on the Canvas course site with explicit expectations. The final research proposal will be written in APA style and include a title page, an introduction section, a methodology section, as well as a reference section. The paper should be double spaced, have 1-inch margins, and use Arial 11 font. The proposal should be between no more than 10 pages, excluding the references. Further details of this assignment will be available on the Canvas course site.

Group Research Proposal Presentation (Due: 4/20/26) – 20% of Final Grade

As a team you will prepare and deliver a presentation of proposed mixed-methods research on a topic. Presentations should include the following:

Introduction: The introduction should include a brief statement (paragraph) of the problem and purpose, and include any definitions of major constructs.

Significance of the Study: This should include a rationale justifying why the study is worthy of the work that will be involved.

Research Question and any needed Hypothesis: This should include specific language that identifies all variables or potential phenomena.

Methods: This section should encompass the typical components discussed under the "Methods" section, such as the overall design, the sampling methods, the data collection methods, and the proposed analysis of the data.

Discussion: Discuss the strengths and limitations of your study. What are the bigger implications of your findings? How should it proceed?

You will add or create images and graphics that help communicate the proposed research, and your team will present this research in the final class. Further details will be provided throughout the semester and several weeks before the due date.

Grading

[The Grading Section includes the detailed methods by which students are graded and the grading rubrics. Typically for Grading Method Detail: You will list each course requirement and due dates (papers, exams, case studies, etc.) List the points or percent associated with each requirement (percentages must sum to 100%).]

Requirement	Due date	Points or % of final grade (% must sum to 100%)
Preparation, In-class Contributions, and In-class Assessments	Ongoing	20%
Research Proposal	4/13/26	60%
Group Research Proposal Presentation	4/20/26 – In-class	20%

Point system used:

Percentage Earned	**Letter Grade**
93-100	A
90-92	A-
87-89	B+
83-86	B
80-82	B-
77-79	C+
73-76	C
70-72	C-
67-69	D+
63-66	D
60-62	D-
Below 60	E

Please be aware that a C- is not an acceptable grade for graduate students. The GPA for graduate students must be 3.0 based on 5000 level courses and above to graduate. A grade of C counts toward a graduate degree only if based on credits in courses numbered 5000 or higher that have been earned with a B+ or higher.

Letter Grade	Grade Points
A	4.0
A-	3.67
B+	3.33
B	3.0
B-	2.67
C+	2.33
C	2.0
C-	1.67
D+	1.33
D	1.0
D-	0.67
E	0.0
WF	0.0
I	0.0
NG	0.0
S-U	0.0

More information may be found on the UF grading policy *[Remove if course is an undergraduate level course.]*
More information may be found on the UF attendance policy *[Remove if course is a graduate level course.]*

Policy Related to Late Work

Please note all faculty are bound by the UF policy for excused absences. For information regarding the UF Attendance Policy see the Registrar website for additional details. I encourage you to please reach out to the instructor if circumstances arise where you need to be absent or submit late work. I will try to balance professionalism with compassion so that we can make alternative plans, when necessary, to help you be successful in this course while prioritizing your emotional and physical well-being.

Any requests for make-ups due to technical issues should be accompanied by the ticket number received from eLearning when the problem was reported to them. The ticket number will document the time and date of the problem. Please e-mail your instructor within 24 hours of the technical difficulty if you wish to request a make-up of a Canvas quiz.

Assessments cannot be made-up except in the case of circumstances that meet the criteria of the University of Florida policy for an excused absence. However, as described above, please reach out if special circumstances occur, and I will work with you as best as possible.

In the event of an absence, inform the instructor as early as possible prior to the class. For all unplanned absences because of accidents or emergency situations, students should contact their instructor as soon as conditions permit. If an absence for one of the above reasons results in missing an assignment, contact the instructor to arrange a make-up alternative, which will typically take place within one week of the due date.

Policy Related to AI Use in This Course

Since the use of AI on assignments can circumvent student learning when it comes to making research decisions, the use of AI is prohibited for all graded components of this course. Thus, it will be considered cheating and students would be violating the UF Regulations 4.040 Student Honor Code and Student Conduct Code.

For AI use on non-graded course activity, it is important to note that many generative AI models (e.g. ChatGPT, ChatSonic, Google Bard etc) place any information that they are provided with into the public domain. When using such tools, you must therefore ensure that they are **never provided with confidential information**. UF AI systems (e.g., Co-Pilot, NaviGator) should never be provided with confidential information. For the avoidance of doubt, the use of such tools is prohibited for generating any confidential communications, including, but not limited to, communications relating to patient records, clients, students and intellectual property. You are also reminded that you should always review the terms and conditions of any third-party software you use (e.g. proof-reading tools) to ensure that any data they are provided with is appropriately protected. Always verify information and sources generated by AI tools. AI has been known to generate false information and to cite non-existent sources. Also, because AI-generated text mines people's intellectual property without appropriate credit, this raises ethical concerns.

Students are responsible for understanding their dynamic data stewardship responsibilities to minimize personal, college, and university risk.
UF Integrated Risk Management – CHATGPT Privacy, Factual Accuracy and Usage Guidelines

ACADEMIC POLICIES & RESOURCES

Information about University Academic Policies and Resources.

STUDENT EXPECTATIONS, ROLES, AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR INPUT

PHHP Student Resources

PHHP's UPTurn (Unified Pathways to Support Wellness) program is a *no-cost mental health and wellness program* that is offered year-round to all PHHP students (undergraduate, graduate and professional level) and students (from any college) who are enrolled in PHHP courses. UPTurn advisors support students on their wellness journeys by curating individualized plans (resources and support) to help them manage academic, social, emotional, and health-related stress.

Interested students are paired with an UPTurn advisor, who meets with each student *virtually* (Zoom, Teams, phone) or *in person* (private office/room in HPNP) for a 45-minute consultation, followed by (if desired):

1. Up to 4 follow-up skills-building visits
2. When needed and appropriate, up to 10 psychotherapy sessions after completion of the 4 follow-up skills-building visits

Note: UPTurn is NOT a crisis/emergency resource. Students who are in crisis are strongly encouraged to use UF's existing crisis support resources.

Students can learn more about UPTurn as well as request an appointment.

Any questions regarding UPTurn can be directed to upturn@phhp.ufl.edu or (352) 273-6850.

Inclusive Learning Environment

Public health and health professions are based on the belief in human dignity and on respect for the individual. As we share our personal beliefs inside or outside of the classroom, it is always with the understanding that we value and respect diversity of background, experience, and opinion, where every individual feels valued. We believe in, and promote, openness and tolerance of differences in ethnicity and culture, and we respect differing personal, spiritual, religious and political values. We further believe that celebrating such diversity enriches the quality of the educational experiences we provide our students and enhances our own personal and professional relationships. We embrace The University of Florida's Non-Discrimination Policy, which reads, "The University shall actively promote equal opportunity policies and practices conforming to laws against discrimination. The University is committed to non-discrimination with respect to race, creed, color, religion, age, disability, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity and expression, marital status, national origin, political opinions or affiliations, genetic information and veteran status as protected under the Vietnam Era Veterans' Readjustment Assistance Act."